CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 05

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



HOSPITALITY

Every guest. Every shift.

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down and tell everyone on site, fast. A practical playbook for hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, written for the busiest nights of the year.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

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A practical playbook for hotels, bars, restaurants and venues: how every shift protects guests and staff, and which rules apply where.

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FOREWORD

In a busy bar or hotel, the first minutes belong to the people on shift.

On the night of the London Bridge and Borough Market attack in June 2017, the attackers moved through a restaurant courtyard, bars and a restaurant on Stoney Street. The Chief Coroner found that all eight people who died did so within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[1] At Manchester Arena a few weeks earlier, a concern raised by a member of the public did not reach anyone who could act on it, partly because a radio channel was busy.[2]

The rules differ from country to country. In the UK, Martyn's Law will require procedures to evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate in venues where 200 or more people can be expected.[3] In the US, federal advice for crowded places is guidance; in the EU, the Commission's good practices are guidance and national rules vary; in Dubai, hotel security conditions are set by regulation.[4,5,6] The task on the night is the same everywhere.

This playbook is for the people who make it work on the busiest night: owners, general managers, duty managers, security leads and operations teams. It covers the roles each shift needs, how to reach guests and staff in minutes, the emergencies that are far more likely than terrorism, a practical toolkit and the regional rules to check. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.



The Crises Control team
Crises Control

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Hospitality safety is decided by the shift on duty, in minutes.

01 · THE OPERATIONAL CHALLENGE

- Busy, noisy venues with bedrooms, terraces and function rooms, staffed by rotating shifts, agency workers and new starters.
- Decisions on the night fall to a duty manager, often without head office, and must be made in minutes.
- Groups run venues under different national rules on security, fire safety and emergency planning.

02 · INCIDENTS AND RISKS TO PREPARE FOR

- An attack or credible threat at or near the venue that needs lockdown or invacuation.
- Fire, medical emergencies, spiking and violence on the busiest nights.
- Power loss, or booking and payment systems failing across every site.
- A multi-venue incident where staff hear from social media before they hear from head office.

03 · KEY RECOMMENDATIONS

- Name a duty manager on every shift with authority to evacuate, invacuate or lock down at once.
- Write four short procedures per site: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.
- Make one alert reach every member of staff, agency included, with replies tracked and silence escalated.
- Plan guest communication for bedrooms, outdoor areas, other languages and guests who need help.
- Check the local rules for each site, country by country, and name an owner for each.

04 · WHAT EFFECTIVE COORDINATION LOOKS LIKE

- Every area of the venue confirms it is secure within minutes, and gaps are chased by name.
- Head office sees every venue at once and sends one instruction, not twelve phone calls.
- Every decision is logged with a time, an owner and a reason.
- Shifts rehearse with the people really on the rota, including new and agency staff.

05 · HOW CRISES CONTROL SUPPORTS THE RESPONSE

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

Ping reaches staff by push, SMS, voice and email with one-tap acknowledgement; silence escalates under the rules you configure.

Incident Manager, Task Manager and Control Centre give the duty manager and head office one log, owned tasks and a live view of every venue.

INTRODUCTION

Three things protect people on the worst night.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. In hospitality the gap shows on the busiest night, when the venues that cope best are the ones where every shift knows who decides, what to do, how to tell everyone fast and how to check that everyone has heard.

One person decides

Every shift has a named duty manager who can declare an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown without waiting for permission, and everyone knows who that is tonight.

Everyone hears it at once

A code phrase, a radio call and an alert to every phone, so the kitchen, the bedrooms and the smoking area hear the same instruction within a minute.

Plans people actually know

Short procedures, briefed at induction and walked through on the late shift, not a binder in the office that nobody has opened.

A plan nobody on shift knows is not a plan.

The UK's Manchester Arena Inquiry found that on the night, plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them".[7] Sending the alert is the easy part. Knowing who heard it, who acts and what is still open is the response.

PART 01

Know your duties.

What the rules ask of hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues in the UK, the US, the EU and the Middle East, the four procedures every venue needs, and the emergencies that are far more likely.

01 Protecting crowded places: what applies where

02 United Kingdom: Martyn's Law

03 Four procedures for every venue

04 Emergency plans for staff: what applies where

05 The emergencies that are far more likely

REGIONAL NOTES

Protecting crowded places: what applies where

Venue security rules differ sharply. Some are law, some are guidance. Check each site against the rules where it operates.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

Martyn's Law, the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025 but is not yet in force; the SIA expects commencement in spring 2027.[3,8] Premises where 200 or more people are expected at once will need public protection procedures.[3]

IN PRACTICE Count the busiest realistic night, staff included. Premises at 800 or more have extra duties. The next pages set out the UK law.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

Federal advice for crowded places is guidance, not law. CISA's action guide for mass gatherings asks owners and operators to Connect, Plan, Train and Report, including public address scripts and Run, Hide, Fight training.[4] The SAFETY Act offers liability protections, by application, for approved anti-terrorism technologies and services.[9]

IN PRACTICE Plan with local law enforcement and fire services, and check state and local rules. OSHA's emergency action plan rule may also apply.

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

The Commission's 2017 Action Plan and 2019 good practices are guidance, not law. They ask operators, hospitality included, for vulnerability assessments, a security plan, a trained security lead with a backup, and a crisis plan to alert, confine or evacuate.[5]

IN PRACTICE Binding duties come from national law and vary by member state. The good practices also call for a spokesperson and key messages agreed in advance.

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST (UAE, SAUDI ARABIA)

Dubai: SIRA's Preventive Systems Manual (2025) requires luxury hotels to have a security operations manager or supervisor around the clock and a surveillance room that can reach guards, hotel officials and emergency services.[6] **Saudi Arabia:** a tourism accommodation licence needs a valid Civil Defense permit and connection to the Shomoos platform.[10]

IN PRACTICE Requirements vary by emirate, star rating and licence. Confirm them with SIRA, the relevant emirate authorities, or the Saudi Ministry of Tourism and Civil Defense.

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

UNITED KINGDOM

United Kingdom: what Martyn's Law asks of hospitality

> **Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday.**

United Kingdom: the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. The Home Office expects an implementation period of at least 24 months, and there is no legal requirement to comply until the duties come into force.[3] The SIA, which will regulate the Act, says it expects the Act to come into force in spring 2027 and will confirm the exact date ahead of time.[8]

The Act covers premises wholly or mainly used for purposes listed in Schedule 1. Statutory guidance says the "food and drink" use "includes bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés and food halls"; "hotels etc" also covers hostels and holiday parks; and nightclubs fall under entertainment and leisure.[11]

Premises are in the standard tier where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected to be present at the same time from time to time, and in the enhanced tier at 800 or more.[3] Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday: a ticketed event, a wedding in the function suite or a full terrace.

Standard tier premises must notify the SIA and have, so far as is reasonably practicable, appropriate public protection procedures for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication. The Home Office says these are simple, low-cost steps that do not require physical alterations or new equipment.[3]

Enhanced tier premises must also have public protection measures covering monitoring, movement, physical safety and security, and the security of information; document compliance and give it to the SIA; and, where the responsible person is an organisation, designate a senior individual.[3]

Penalties reach £10,000 for standard duty premises, and £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue for enhanced duty premises.[3] Existing premises will have three months from commencement to notify the SIA, and changes must be notified within 28 days.[12]

FOUR PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

Four procedures every venue needs, wherever it operates. The definitions are the UK Home Office's, written for Martyn's Law, and they work anywhere.[3]

Evacuation

"Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises." Know every exit, including through the kitchen, and where guests go once they are out.[3]

Invacuation

"Moving people away from danger to a place within the premises." A function room, back corridor or cellar away from glass and the main doors.[3]

Lockdown

"Securing the premises to prevent individuals entering or leaving." Who locks which door, who drops the shutters, how fast, and on every shift.[3]

Communication

"Ensuring information is provided to individuals at the premises." Staff, guests, bedrooms, terraces, toilets, contractors and the next shift.[3]

United Kingdom: the Home Office's own example is a 400-seat restaurant: two evacuation routes, nominated staff who lock doors and close shutters on the shift manager's instruction, and a short briefing for every new starter at induction.[3]

REGIONAL NOTES

Emergency plans for staff: what applies where

Alongside venue security, workplace safety law in most places expects a plan for emergencies and named people to carry it out.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

The Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations 1999 require employers to set up procedures for serious and imminent danger, and to nominate enough competent people to implement them as far as they relate to evacuation.[13]

IN PRACTICE Use the same named roles on each shift for fire, medical emergencies and Martyn's Law procedures, so nobody has to learn two systems.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

Where an OSHA standard requires one, an emergency action plan under 29 CFR 1910.38 must be written (it may be oral with 10 or fewer employees) and cover reporting, evacuation, accounting for employees, rescue and medical duties, and an alarm system.[14]

IN PRACTICE Review the plan with each employee when they join, when their role changes and when the plan changes, seasonal staff included.

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

The OSH Framework Directive 89/391/EEC requires employers to take the necessary measures for first aid, fire-fighting and the evacuation of workers.[15]

IN PRACTICE It is applied through national law, so the detail and inspection regime differ by country. Check the rules in each country where you operate.

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST (UAE)

NCEMA's national business continuity standard, AE/SCNS/NCEMA 7000:2021, states that it applies to all UAE entities and that organisations must endeavour to continue essential operations at predefined minimum levels.[16]

IN PRACTICE For hotel groups in the UAE, continuity plans for booking, payment and power failures fit this standard. In Saudi Arabia, licences also depend on Civil Defense approval.

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

OTHER EMERGENCIES

The emergencies that are far more likely

Terrorism is rare. Fire, medical emergencies, spiking, power and system failures are not. The same roles and alerts handle them all.

EMERGENCY	FIRST ACTION ON SITE	FIRST ACTION FOR MANAGERS
Fire alarm in a full venue	Evacuate by the plan. Sweep sections and bedrooms. Do not let guests collect coats or go back in.	Account for staff and guests from the booking and room lists. Meet the fire service with the plan.
Medical emergency	Call the emergency services, send for the defibrillator and a first aider, clear space and send someone to guide the ambulance.	Look after witnesses and staff, record what happened and check first aid cover for the rest of the night.
Suspected spiking	Stay with the person, get help and call police or an ambulance if needed. Keep the drink if you can.	Report it, keep CCTV and brief door staff. **United Kingdom:** police received 6,732 reports in a year to April 2023.[17]
Power failure	Emergency lighting check, stop cooking, keep exits clear, and decide quickly whether to evacuate.	Call the supplier or facilities, plan for lifts, fridges, tills and door locks, and tell arriving guests.
Booking or payment systems down	Switch to the paper booking list and offline or cash procedure. Do not keep restarting terminals.	Find out whether it is an outage or an attack, and tell sites what still works. A 2022 cyber incident disrupted IHG's booking channels.[18]
Violence or disorder	Make safe, call the emergency services if anyone is in danger, and do not detain. Staff safety first.	Support the staff involved, keep CCTV and review staffing for the next nights.

PART 02

Incident scenarios.

A severity ladder every shift can use, the first hour of the worst night, one incident across three venues, three scenarios to rehearse and the actions still open the morning after.

01 A hospitality severity ladder

02 The first hour

03 One night, three venues and head office

04 Three scenarios to rehearse

05 Tracking what is still outstanding

SEVERITY

A hospitality severity ladder for every shift

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later. The duty manager can declare any level.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An attack or credible threat at or next to the venue. A fire with people unaccounted for. A crowd crush or several casualties.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Everyone on site, the on-call general manager, the head office crisis team and security leads. Emergency services first.

Code phrase · radio · PA · SMS · voice

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

A full evacuation on a busy night. A suspicious item. A serious assault or suspected spiking needing hospital. Power lost in service. Booking or payment systems down across sites.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, area or operations manager, IT or facilities on call.

Radio · SMS · push · escalate after 10 min

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

One site's tills or booking system failing. A guest collapse. An aggressive group removed. People trapped in a lift.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk.

Radio · push · email

SEV 4

Minor

TRIGGERS

Suspicious behaviour reported and resolved. A near miss. A single device fault. Verbal abuse logged.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, recorded for the weekly review and trend reporting.

App · email

THE FIRST HOUR

Saturday, 22:15: an attack outside

Illustrative: a city-centre hotel with a bar and restaurant, around 550 people on site. Police instructions always come first.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Door team sees people running from the street** Shouts of a knife attack nearby. The door supervisor radios the code phrase to the duty manager.	DOOR SUPERVISOR
T+00:01	**Lockdown and invacuation declared** Doors locked, shutters down, music off. Guests moved away from glass to the function room.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:02	**Emergency services called, log started** What, where, which direction, how many on site. Every decision from now is logged with a time.	RECEPTION
T+00:03	**Every member of staff alerted** Code phrase on the PA, radio and an alert to every phone. Staff reply when their area is safe, and replies are tracked by area.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:06	**Guests in bedrooms told to stay put** Room phones and text: stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows.	NIGHT MANAGER
T+00:12	**Everyone accounted for, escalated** This is where it often goes wrong: smokers, agency staff and anyone outside. Chase every gap by name. On-call general manager and head office alerted.	SHIFT MANAGERS
T+01:00	**Police briefed, people cared for** Floor plans and numbers to police. Guests and staff stay inside until police advise otherwise. Open actions move to a tracker with owners.	GENERAL MANAGER

ACROSS VENUES

One night, three venues and head office

Illustrative: a group with a hotel, a bar on the same street and a restaurant 1 km away. Red cards show where a multi-venue response breaks down; police instructions always come first.

	22:15	22:17	22:20	22:30	22:45	23:30
Hotel (on scene)	Door team radios the code phrase ◆ Duty manager declares lockdown	Emergency services called; alert raised with location where available	Staff replies tracked area by area	Three staff unaccounted for, chased by name	Guests in bedrooms told to stay put	Police briefed with floor plans and numbers
Bar, same street	! Shouting outside; staff unsure who decides	◆ Duty manager locks doors and invacuates	! Two agency staff missing from alert list		Agency staff found; head count complete	
Restaurant, 1 km away			! Staff first hear of it on social media	Guests held inside, away from the cordon	! Guests pushing to leave before police advice	◆ Guests released only on police advice
On-call operations manager		Alerted; warns every nearby venue		◆ Decides restaurant takes no new guests	Off-duty staff told not to travel in	Open actions handed to named owners
Head office crisis team			Crisis team activated, roles assigned	Live view of venues, replies and gaps	◆ Decides to close all city venues tonight	Holding statement out; bookings contacted

Action · Decision · Where it goes wrong · Monitored

> Three things decide how this night goes: every venue hears from the group, not from social media; every person on shift, agency staff included, is on the alert list; and each decision has one named owner who does not wait for someone more senior.

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse

CITY-CENTRE BAR AND NIGHTCLUB, 900 CAPACITY

01:00: a fight spills inside, then reports of a weapon outside

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Music still playing, doors open, and staff waiting for someone senior to decide.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Each section replies when secure; silent sections are chased by name within minutes.

WHO DECIDES

The duty manager declares lockdown; the door supervisor controls who comes in.

REHEARSE

A five-minute lockdown drill before opening.

HOTEL, 140 BEDROOMS AND A FUNCTION SUITE

21:30: a fire alarm during a 300-guest gala dinner

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Guests returning for coats, drivers blocking the fire lane and bedrooms missed.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Area sweeps and the room list checked off at the assembly point.

WHO DECIDES

The duty manager runs the evacuation; the night manager owns the bedrooms.

REHEARSE

A walk-through with the events team and night porter.

RESTAURANT GROUP, 12 SITES

18:00 on the busiest Saturday of the year: bookings and payments fail at every site

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Each manager calls IT separately and sites get different instructions.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Every site acknowledges one instruction; head office sees who is trading.

WHO DECIDES

The head office incident lead decides on paper and cash; each manager runs their site.

REHEARSE

One site running on paper for an hour.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

Sunday, 11:00: what is still open

Illustrative, the morning after the three-venue incident. Every action has one owner, a time and a way of checking it is done, so nothing depends on memory.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Account for every member of staff at all three venues	Operations manager	Sat 22:45	DONE	Replies on the alert, gaps called by name
Updated holding statement agreed	Head office comms	Sun 09:00	DONE	Approved version saved in the log
Keep CCTV from all three venues for police	Security lead	Sun 09:00	IN PROGRESS	Police reference recorded in the log
Contact guests booked today at closed venues	Reservations	Sun 10:00	OVERDUE	Send report from the booking system
Add the two missing agency staff to alert lists	Operations manager	Sun 10:00	OVERDUE	Test alert, reply received
Welfare call to staff who saw the incident	General manager	Sun 12:00	IN PROGRESS	Named list, each call logged
Brief the next shift before any reopening	Duty managers	Sun 14:00	OPEN	Signed shift briefing record
Decide whether the hotel bar reopens tonight	Head office incident lead	Sun 15:00	BLOCKED	Waiting for police to lift the cordon
Notify the insurer and keep the timeline	Finance	Mon 12:00	OPEN	Insurer reference in the log

> Review the board at a fixed time, not when someone remembers. Overdue and blocked actions go to the head office incident lead, and the board becomes the starting point for the post-incident review.

PART 03

Respond and recover.

The roles every shift needs, how to reach staff and guests, what to do before your busiest season, two templates for every shift and a plan with owners.

01 Roles on every shift

02 Reaching staff and guests fast

03 Talking to guests

04 Before your busiest season

05 Shift briefing record and area sweep log

06 Week, month, quarter

ROLES

Who does what, on every shift

Name the people at the start of each shift. Everyone with a role in the procedures must know it, and so must the person covering their break.

01 Duty manager: decides and declares

Has authority to call evacuation, invacuation or lockdown at once, and to call the emergency services. Does not wait for head office.

02 Door and security team: first eyes

Spot and report early, lock doors, stop people entering, and give police clear information on arrival.

03 Bar and floor staff: move the room

Each person owns a section: move guests from glass and doors, sweep toilets and terraces, and report when clear.

04 Reception or night manager: the hotel

Calls the emergency services, reaches guests in bedrooms and holds the guest list and today's function bookings.

05 Kitchen and back of house: the rear

Secure the back doors and delivery yard, cut gas if instructed, and know which rooms can be used as safe areas.

06 Communicator: who has heard

Sends the alert, tracks who has replied and chases the rest, and logs who was told what and when.

COMMUNICATION

Reaching guests and staff in minutes

Noise, music, bedrooms, outdoor areas and staff on breaks make hospitality hard to reach. Use more than one route, and confirm who has heard.

A code phrase everyone knows

A neutral phrase on the PA or radio that tells staff what is happening without alarming guests. Change it if it leaks.

Stop the music, light the room

Music off and house lights up so announcements can be heard, unless lockdown means lights off on police advice.

An alert to every phone

One message to staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, with a reply to confirm. Chase anyone who does not answer.

Guests you cannot see

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, smoking areas and private dining rooms each need a named person or route.

People off site

The next shift, off-duty staff and families. Tell them not to come in, and keep updates on a schedule. Public advice differs: **UK** RUN, HIDE, TELL; **US** Run, Hide, Fight.[4,19]

> **At Manchester Arena, a steward without a radio passed on a concern; a colleague with one tried to report it but someone else was talking, and it went no further.[2] Never rely on a single channel.**

GUEST COMMUNICATION

Talking to guests: what to consider

Guests do not know your code phrases, your layout or your staff. Plan how each group is reached, and agree what nobody says.

GUESTS	HOW TO REACH THEM	WHAT TO SAY, AND WHAT TO AVOID
In bars, restaurants and function rooms	Music off, lights up. Staff in each section give the same short instruction face to face.	Say what to do, not why: "Please come with me to the back room now." Do not shout words that cause panic.
In bedrooms	Room phone, a text to the mobile given at booking, and door knocks only where it is safe.	"Stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows. Next update by [time]."
Who do not speak the local language	Short translated lines in the languages your guests most often speak, plus showing the way.	Short sentences and plain words. No idioms, and never the staff code phrase.
Who need help to move or to hear an alarm	Ask at booking and check-in; name a member of staff for each guest on the shift.	Tell them who is coming, where to wait and how they will be told it is safe.
Outside: terraces, smoking areas, queues	Bring them in or move them away, as the duty manager decides. In lockdown the door team controls entry.	"Come inside now" or "Move away from the building", with a clear direction.
Everyone, at every stage	One approved message, repeated, with a time for the next update.	Never guess the cause or casualties, name anyone involved or post on social media. Media get the holding line.

PEAK READINESS

Six steps before your busiest season

Peak weeks bring the biggest crowds, the most new staff and the longest nights. Finish these before the first big event.

01 Count your peak nights

Work out how many people, including staff, can reasonably be expected on your busiest nights, function rooms and terraces included. In the UK it decides your Martyn's Law tier.

02 Name the duty manager for every night

Publish who decides on each shift through the peak, with an on-call general manager behind them.

03 Brief every seasonal starter

A short induction on the four procedures and their role, on their first shift, before they serve a guest.

04 Walk through a lockdown

Ten minutes with the late shift: which doors lock, where guests go, who checks the toilets and terrace.

05 Load every contact, including agency staff

Mobile numbers for everyone on the rota, tested with a short alert that asks for a reply.

06 Plan for the outage

Paper booking lists, an offline payment or cash procedure and a known number for every supplier.

TEMPLATE

Shift safety briefing record

Complete at the start of every shift, in two minutes, and keep it with the incident log. Agency and new staff sign the same record as everyone else.

DATE AND SHIFT	DUTY MANAGER (DECIDES)	CODE PHRASE BRIEFED	SAFE AREA AND LOCKDOWN DOORS	NEW OR AGENCY STAFF BRIEFED	TEST ALERT REPLIES	SIGNED
Sat, late	*[Name], on-call GM [name]*	*Yes, all sections*	*Function room; front, side, yard doors*	*3 agency, named, briefed*	*41 of 42, 1 chased*	*[Initials]*

Illustrative template. If the test alert does not reach everyone on the rota, fix the contact list before service starts, not after the incident.

TEMPLATE

Area sweep and head count log

Used during an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown. Each area has one named person who sweeps it, counts who is there and reports back to the duty manager.

AREA	SWEPT BY	TIME CLEAR	GUESTS IN AREA	STAFF IN AREA	NEEDS HELP OR MISSING	REPORTED TO AND TIME
Terrace and smoking area	*[Name], floor*	*22:19*	*14*	*2*	*1 guest in wheelchair, staff with her*	*Duty manager 22:20*

Illustrative template. List every area before the shift starts: bars, toilets, terraces, function rooms, kitchen, cellar, bedrooms by floor. An area with no name is an area nobody checks.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Name a duty manager for every night of the next peak period. Brief the four procedures and the code phrase at every shift start.	General manager
This week	Load every staff mobile, including agency and seasonal staff, and test an alert that asks for a reply.	Operations manager
This month	Count peak numbers for every site and room. List the security, fire and licensing rules that apply to each site, by country, with an owner.	Head of security, with legal
This month	Write one page per site: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication. Walk through lockdown on a late shift.	General manager
This quarter	**United Kingdom:** prepare to notify the SIA within three months of commencement. Elsewhere: confirm licence and civil defence conditions are current.	Chief operating officer
This quarter	Run a joint exercise with head office on an attack nearby and a system outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Head of security

PRACTICAL TOOLKIT

Seven tools for your next incident

The same seven tools appear in every Crises Control playbook, with examples for your industry. Copy them, adapt them and rehearse with them.

01 **Readiness assessment** 28
Score eight areas from 0 to 3 and find your weakest link.

02 **Roles and responsibilities matrix** 29
Who is responsible, accountable, consulted and informed for each activity.

03 **Incident decision log** 30
Record every material decision, who made it and why, as it happens.

04 **Escalation workflow** 31
Four levels, their triggers, who is alerted and who decides.

05 **Communication templates** 32
Ready-to-send messages for staff, customers, regulators, partners and media.

06 **Tabletop exercise** 33
A ready-to-run scenario with timed injects and questions for the room.

07 **Post-incident review template** 34
Eight prompts that turn an incident into lessons and owned actions.

> Every tool works on paper. In Crises Control the same roles, escalation rules, templates and logs can be set up in the platform, so they run during the incident and leave a record afterwards.

TOOLKIT 01 · READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your hospitality organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every member of staff on shift reached within minutes, including agency and new starters.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation by rule? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement from each area of the venue, with escalation when one stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One duty manager can start evacuation, invacuation or lockdown for the whole site.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the duty manager, security, head office and emergency services liaison.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Public protection procedures (such as those required under Martyn's Law in the UK) run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff, areas secured and guests accounted for.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that shows what the venue did and when, for the regulator or an inquiry.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Shift-level drills, including peak seasons and the busiest nights.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

TOOLKIT 02 · ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES MATRIX

Who does what in a lockdown, invacuation or evacuation

By shift role. Write tonight's names against each column at the start of the shift.

ACTIVITY	DUTY MANAGER	SUPERVISOR	DOOR AND SECURITY	FRONT OF HOUSE	KITCHEN	HEAD OFFICE
Spot and report a threat by code phrase or one-touch alert	A	R	R	R	R	·
Declare evacuation, invacuation or lockdown	A	I	C	I	I	I
Call the emergency services and start the timed incident log	A	R	I	R	·	I
Lock front doors and stop people entering	A	I	R	C	·	·
Secure rear doors, the delivery yard and gas	A	I	·	·	R	·
Move guests from glass and doors to the safe area	A	R	C	R	I	·
Reach guests in bedrooms, toilets and terraces	A	R	·	R	·	·
Alert all staff, track replies and chase the silent	A	R	I	I	I	I
Head count of staff and guests by area	A	R	R	R	R	I
Brief police on arrival with plans and numbers	A	C	R	C	·	I
Media, social media and tomorrow's bookings	C	·	·	I	·	A

R Responsible: does the work A Accountable: owns the decision C Consulted I Informed

> In a smaller venue one person may hold several columns. What matters is that every row has a name tonight, and that the duty manager never waits for head office to act on safety.

TOOLKIT 03 · INCIDENT DECISION LOG

Every call the duty manager makes, on the record

Start the log when the incident starts, on paper if you have to. The example row is illustrative, from the attack-outside scenario in Part 02.

TIME	DECISION	OPTIONS CONSIDERED	DECIDED BY	RATIONALE	EVIDENCE OR REFERENCE
22:16	*Lockdown; bar and restaurant guests invacuated to the function room*	*Evacuate to the street; invacuate; carry on with doors watched*	*Duty manager*	*Reported knife attack on the street; main exits face it*	*Door radio call 22:15; CCTV ref*

Log decisions as they are made, not afterwards. Include decisions not to act. The log is the backbone of the timeline your board, auditors and regulators will ask for.

TOOLKIT 04 · ESCALATION WORKFLOW

How an incident climbs from the shift to head office

Illustrative timings, to be set by each operator. Each level follows the severity ladder, and escalating never takes away the duty manager's authority to act at once on site.

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 1 **On-shift report**	Suspicious behaviour, an unattended bag, a near miss or a guest unwell. Severity 4.	The duty manager, by radio, the code phrase or a one-touch alert with location where available.	Duty manager, after a quick check with the person who reported it.
↓ ESCALATE IF THE ITEM CANNOT BE CLEARED WITHIN 5 MINUTES OR ANYONE IS AT RISK			
LEVEL 2 **Venue incident**	A guest collapse, an aggressive group, a lift entrapment or one site's tills down. Severity 3.	Every member of staff on shift, and the on-call general manager.	Duty manager. The general manager is informed, not asked for permission.
↓ ESCALATE IF THE VENUE EVACUATES, INVACUATES OR LOCKS DOWN, OR POLICE ARE CALLED TO A THREAT			
LEVEL 3 **Major venue incident**	Full evacuation, lockdown, a suspicious item or a serious assault. Severity 2.	On-call general manager, operations manager, off-duty staff and the next shift.	Duty manager on site. Operations manager decides on closing and the next shift.
↓ ESCALATE IF ANOTHER VENUE IS AFFECTED, ANYONE IS SERIOUSLY HURT, OR MEDIA ARRIVE			
LEVEL 4 **Group crisis**	An attack or credible threat, several venues affected, or a group-wide system outage. Severity 1.	Head office crisis team, every duty manager nearby, security lead and communications.	Head office incident lead for closures, statements and bookings; duty managers for safety on site.

Silence is a trigger too. If the person alerted at any level has not acknowledged within 5 minutes, the alert goes to the next named person under the escalation rules you set, and the gap is recorded for the review.

TOOLKIT 05 · COMMUNICATION TEMPLATES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and calm. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always say when the next update will come.

SMS · STAFF ON DUTY

139 chars

> LOCKDOWN at [venue]. Move guests away from doors and glass to [area]. Doors stay locked. Do not go outside. Reply 1 when your area is safe.

Under 160 characters, so it arrives as one message.

SMS · HOTEL GUESTS

144 chars

> [Hotel]: police are dealing with an incident nearby. Please stay in your room, lock the door and keep away from windows. Next update by [22:45].

Only to guests who have given a mobile number. Translate for your most common guest languages.

EMAIL · GUESTS WITH BOOKINGS

> Because of an incident near [venue], we are closed this evening. Please do not travel to us. Your booking will be [moved or refunded] and we will contact you by [time].

Send from the booking system so it reaches tonight's and tomorrow's bookings.

EMAIL · REGULATOR OR LICENSING AUTHORITY

> Incident at [venue], [address], [licence or registration number]. At [time] on [date] we [locked down / evacuated] after [brief facts]. Injuries known: [number or none]. Police reference [ref]. Contact: [name, number].

Only where your licence or local rules require it. Facts only; confirm form and timing with your legal team.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND BOOKING PLATFORMS

> Our booking and payment systems are offline while we investigate. Deliveries continue as booked. Do not act on any request to change bank details; call [known number].

Attackers often follow an outage with fake payment requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an incident near [venue] this evening. Our priority is the safety of our guests and team, and we are following police advice. We will share more when we can.

TOOLKIT 06 · TABLETOP EXERCISE

Ninety minutes with the late shift

An illustrative exercise to run in a quiet afternoon slot. Read each inject aloud, give the room three minutes, and record the answers and the gaps.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
90 minutes, including a 20-minute debrief	Duty managers, a supervisor, door team lead, reception and head office operations	Test the lockdown decision, reaching every member of staff and guest, and the handover to head office	Head of security, or an outside facilitator who does not take part

00:00	INJECT 1	Friday, 21:40. During a 300-guest gala dinner, a bar supervisor reports an unattended bag in the function suite cloakroom.	DISCUSS Who decides what happens next? What is the first instruction, on which channel, and who hears it?
00:15	INJECT 2	The duty manager moves guests out of the suite. The usual assembly point is next to the outside wall of the cloakroom.	DISCUSS Where do guests go instead? How do staff in other areas know the plan has changed?
00:30	INJECT 3	Twelve of 40 staff have not replied to the alert, including four agency staff and the night porter.	DISCUSS Who chases them, and how? Do we know their names and numbers tonight?
00:45	INJECT 4	Guests in bedrooms above the suite are calling reception, and a video of the evacuation is spreading online.	DISCUSS What do we tell guests in rooms, and in which languages? Who speaks for the venue, and what do staff post?
01:00	INJECT 5	Police confirm the bag is lost property. The event organiser asks to carry on.	DISCUSS Who decides to stand down? How is the stand-down sent, and what is recorded?
01:15	INJECT 6	Monday. Head office asks for a timeline of the first fifteen minutes.	DISCUSS Could we produce it from our records? What is missing, and who fixes it by when?

> Run it with the late shift as it really is, agency staff and new starters included. The answer "I would ring the general manager" is a finding: decide who acts without asking.

TOOLKIT 07 · POST-INCIDENT REVIEW TEMPLATE

Review the night, fix the system

Hold it within a week, with the people who were on shift. The aim is to fix the system, not to blame the person. Use the Incident decision log and the actions tracker as the record.

INCIDENT	DATE	SEVERITY	REVIEW LEAD

01 What happened, and when

The timeline from the first report to stand-down, taken from the log, not from memory.

02 How we found out

Who spotted it, how it was reported and how long it took to reach the duty manager.

03 The decision

Who declared what, and when. Did anyone wait for permission they did not need?

04 Reaching staff

How many replied, how fast, and who was missed: agency, breaks, off-site, new starters.

05 Reaching guests

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, other languages and guests who needed help.

06 Venues and head office

How other venues and head office heard, and any conflicting instructions.

07 People affected

Welfare of guests and staff, first aid given and the support offered afterwards.

08 Actions and checks

Each fix with one owner and a date, and how the next drill will prove it works.

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

THE DUTIES

- ? Which security, fire and licensing rules apply to each of our sites, in each country, and who owns them?
- ? Could every site evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate tonight, and when was it last practised?
- ? Who on tonight's rota can declare a lockdown without asking anyone?

THE PEOPLE

- ? How long would it take to reach every member of staff on duty, and to know who had not replied?
- ? How would we reach guests in bedrooms, on terraces and in private dining rooms, in their own language?
- ? Are our seasonal and agency staff briefed to the same standard as the regulars?

CHECKLIST

Are your venues ready?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Peak numbers counted for every site**
  Including staff, function rooms and outside areas.

- [ ] **Four procedures written for every site**
  Evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

- [ ] **A named duty manager on every shift**
  With authority to act at once.

- [ ] **Every staff member briefed on their role**
  Including seasonal, agency and night staff.

- [ ] **One alert reaches everyone on duty**
  With replies tracked and non-responders chased.

- [ ] **A way to reach guests in bedrooms**
  And in toilets, terraces, private rooms and other languages.

- [ ] **Outage procedures for bookings and payments**
  Tested on a real shift.

- [ ] **Local rules checked for every site**
  UK: ready to notify the SIA. Elsewhere: licence, civil defence and security conditions current.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Crowded place
A location that is easy to access and draws large numbers of people, such as a bar, hotel lobby or venue.

Invacuation
Moving people away from danger to a safer place inside the premises.

Lockdown
Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving.

Duty manager
The person on each shift with authority to declare an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

Martyn's Law (UK)
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, named after Martyn Hett, who was killed at Manchester Arena.

Standard and enhanced tier (UK)
Premises where 200 to 799, or 800 or more, people can reasonably be expected at the same time.

SIA (UK)
The Security Industry Authority, the regulator for Martyn's Law.

Run, Hide, Fight (US)
US public guidance for an active attacker; the UK equivalent is RUN, HIDE, TELL.

SAFETY Act (US)
A US law offering liability protections, by application, for approved anti-terrorism technologies and services.

SIRA (Dubai)
Dubai's Security Industry Regulatory Agency, which sets security conditions for hotels.

NCEMA 7000 (UAE)
The UAE's national business continuity management standard.

Shomoos (Saudi Arabia)
The security platform that licensed tourism accommodation in Saudi Arabia must connect to.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When an attack happens outside a busy venue at 22:15, the alert is minute one. Protecting guests depends on every member of staff knowing their role, lockdown or invacuation starting at once, guests being told clearly, and a record of the first fifteen minutes.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module of this incident management software does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01

ESCALATE

SOS

Frontline staff raise an alert from the mobile app, with location where available.

02

START

Ping

Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03

COORDINATE

Incident Manager

Authorised users activate the incident and its response plan, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04

EXECUTE

Task Manager

Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05

OPERATE

Control Centre

Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06

PROVE

Audit & Reporting

Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07

ASSIST

CRAiG

AI assistant (beta) that answers questions and summarises incident data. People make every decision.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation

Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination

Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility

Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability

Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

How the modules work together in a hospitality incident

Crises Control is an Operational Incident Coordination Platform. This is the three-venue night in this playbook, from the first alarm to the review. Each step is an outcome, not a feature.

01 ESCALATE
SOS
The door supervisor raises the alarm with a press-and-hold SOS, sharing location where available, so the duty manager knows at once.

02 START
Ping
Every member of staff on shift, agency staff included, gets the lockdown alert by push, SMS or voice and replies when their area is safe.

03 COORDINATE
Incident Manager
The duty manager launches the incident and its response plan, assigns roles and keeps one log shared with head office.

04 EXECUTE
Task Manager
Locking doors, sweeping toilets and terraces, reaching bedrooms and the head count become owned tasks from the plan you built, with completion tracked.

05 OPERATE
Control Centre
Head office sees every venue: who was alerted, who acknowledged, task progress and gaps, without phoning each site.

06 PROVE
Audit & Reporting
A timestamped record of every alert, reply, decision logged and task is ready to export for the review, the insurer and the regulator.

07 ASSIST
CRAiG
CRAiG (beta) answers questions about the incident data, such as which areas have not confirmed they are secure, within each user's permissions.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

WHAT IS STANDARD, WHAT IS CONFIGURED

Clear about what the platform does.

Some capabilities work as standard. Others depend on how your team sets up plans, groups and rules, or on connecting your own systems. Your demonstration and implementation plan confirm what applies to you.

STANDARD

Included in how each module works.

- SOS press-and-hold alert from the mobile app, raising an incident and sharing location where available
- Ping alerts by push, SMS, voice, email and desktop, with one-tap acknowledgement
- Incident Manager workspace, roles and a single communication log
- Task Manager tasks with owners and deadlines when a plan is activated
- Control Centre live view of status, acknowledgements, tasks and locations
- Audit & Reporting: timestamped records, exportable as PDF or CSV
- CRAiG (beta): answers questions and summarises your incident data within each user's permissions

CONFIGURED

Set up by your team to match your plans.

- Response plans, task lists and message templates per incident type
- Groups, sites and audiences to target
- Escalation rules and timings when people do not respond
- Cascading from one channel to the next
- Response options people can choose when they acknowledge

INTEGRATIONS

Connected to your other systems, where configured.

- Directory sync with Microsoft Entra ID, SCIM or scheduled file import
- Single sign-on with Entra ID, Google Workspace or Okta
- The Microsoft Teams app, enabled by your administrator
- Triggers from monitoring or other systems, set up as an integration project

> Crises Control does not detect incidents on its own. Incidents are raised by people, through SOS, the app or the web, or by connected systems where an integration has been configured. From that point the platform coordinates the response.

USE CASES

How organisations use Crises Control in hospitality

From the first alert to the final record: the incidents this platform is used for, and how the modules work together in each.

Guest and on-site user emergency communication

CUSTOMER EXAMPLE

TRIGGER An emergency affects guests, visitors or staff at a hotel, resort or holiday park

Send emergency messages and updates to relevant people on site, using targeted groups or locations where configured.

Ping | Incident Manager | audience targeting

Security incident response

CUSTOMER EXAMPLE

TRIGGER A security event requires immediate action from security officers and managers

Launch an incident, notify security personnel and management, assign and track tasks, and generate an incident record after resolution.

Incident Manager | Ping | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Business continuity plan activation

CUSTOMER EXAMPLE

TRIGGER A disruption requires a hospitality business to activate continuity arrangements

Distribute the relevant business continuity plan to staff and issue role-specific tasks so responsibilities are clear and tracked.

Incident Manager | Ping | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Two-way staff communication

CUSTOMER REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER Managers need updates or responses from staff during an incident

Use two-way communications to gather information, coordinate the response and maintain visibility of staff updates.

Incident Manager | mobile app two-way communications | Ping

Multi-site guest and staff communication

CUSTOMER EXAMPLE

TRIGGER An incident or service disruption affects several venues or holiday parks

Communicate with relevant people across affected sites and provide consistent updates as the situation develops.

Ping | Incident Manager | Control Centre

Customer examples are based on how customers use Crises Control today; customer names have been removed. Customer requirements describe needs raised by customers or in evaluations. Intended, suggested and illustrative use cases show how the platform can be applied and are not presented as existing customer deployments. Capabilities marked 'where configured' or 'where available' depend on each organisation's set-up.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is spotted and escalated, and what you must configure.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location where available, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

SOURCES

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BOOK YOUR HOSPITALITY PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a venue lockdown run end to end.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. In a live, 30-minute demonstration built around a hospitality incident, you will see how our incident management software, an Operational Incident Coordination Platform, takes one incident from first alert to final report. Bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A door supervisor raises a lockdown alert in one touch with SOS.
02	PING	Every member of staff on shift across the venue is alerted and acknowledges.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	The duty manager activates the incident and assigns roles by area.
04	TASK MANAGER	Lockdown, guest communication and head count become owned tasks.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	Head office sees every venue, area secured and staff accounted for.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	A timeline of the first fifteen minutes is produced.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG helps the duty manager find information in the platform and summarise the incident so far.

Book your demonstration →

crises-control.com/hospitality-crisis-management-software/

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SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT Safe in a crowd